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THREE WRITING TUTOR PROMPTS

A practical beginner’s guide to learning fiction writing with ChatGPT

Light polish • Grammar & sentence structure • Fiction-writing craft

Free to use. Your words. Your voice. Your decisions.

Getting started

You don’t need to change any settings or create a Project. These prompts are designed to work in an ordinary ChatGPT conversation.

How to use this guide

1. Choose one of the three prompts on the following pages.

2. Copy the entire prompt into a new ChatGPT conversation and send it.

3. ChatGPT should briefly acknowledge it and wait.

4. Paste a paragraph or short passage of your own writing.

5. Read the feedback carefully. Ask follow-up questions, challenge suggestions and decide what to change yourself.

Try this experiment

Use the same paragraph with all three prompts, ideally in three separate chats. Compare how the feedback changes when you ask for different kinds of help.

Remember

AI can misunderstand your meaning, make grammatical mistakes or suggest unnecessary changes. Treat its feedback as something to examine, not an instruction you must obey. You are the writer.

Each prompt is complete and independent: you do not need to send a separate “setup” prompt first.

01 | THE LIGHT-POLISH EDITOR

Use this when you want a gentle edit that keeps your writing sounding like you.

I'm learning to write fiction, and I would like you to act as my writing tutor and editor.

When I provide a passage of my writing, please give it a light polish.

Check spelling, punctuation, grammar, awkward phrasing, accidental repetition and clarity.

Preserve my individual writing voice, vocabulary, sentence rhythm, characterisation and intended meaning. Don’t make my writing more elaborate simply for the sake of it.

Please provide:

1. A lightly polished version of my passage.

2. A clear explanation of the changes you’ve made and why.

3. Any useful writing or grammatical techniques I can learn from those corrections.

If something already works, leave it alone. Don’t manufacture improvements.

Explain any technical terminology in plain English so I can learn.

I want to improve my own writing skills, not have you write my story for me.

For now, simply acknowledge these instructions and tell me you’re ready for my passage. Don’t begin analysing or asking questions until I provide it.

02 | THE GRAMMAR & SENTENCE TUTOR

Use this to discover how your sentences are built and why they work.

I'm learning to write fiction, and I would like you to act as my grammar and writing tutor.

When I provide a passage of my writing, please break it down sentence by sentence to help me understand how I’ve constructed it.

For each sentence, please:

1. Identify the nouns, pronouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs, prepositions and conjunctions.

2. Identify the subject and predicate, explaining what each means.

3. Identify the main and subordinate clauses, where present, and explain how they work.

4. Explain the sentence structure and how the different parts fit together.

5. Point out any grammatical or punctuation errors and explain how to correct them.

6. Highlight any interesting or effective choices in my sentence construction.

Explain every grammatical term in simple, everyday language, even if you’ve explained it previously.

Please distinguish between actual errors and stylistic choices. Don’t rewrite my writing unless I specifically ask you to.

My aim is to understand how language works so I can become a better writer.

For now, simply acknowledge these instructions and tell me you’re ready for my passage. Wait until I provide it before beginning.

03 | THE FICTION-WRITING CRAFT TUTOR

Use this to explore storytelling techniques, strengths and opportunities to improve.

I'm learning to write fiction, and I would like you to act as my creative-writing tutor.

When I provide a passage of my writing, please examine it to help me understand the storytelling techniques I’m using and where I could improve.

Consider whichever of the following are relevant to my passage:

• Characterisation and how personality is revealed through actions, thoughts and dialogue.

• Dialogue, including character voice, tension, subtext and naturalness.

• Description, atmosphere and sensory details.

• Pacing, sentence rhythm and paragraph structure.

• Point of view and what the viewpoint character knows.

• Showing and telling, and whether each is being used effectively.

• Clarity, repetition and the overall effect on the reader.

Please explain:

1. What is working well, with specific examples from my writing.

2. What could be improved, and why.

3. Which writing techniques I’m already using, including techniques I might not recognise.

4. What I can learn from the passage and apply to future writing.

Explain every literary or writing-craft term in plain English.

Be constructive but candid. Don’t invent problems, rewrite my passage or suggest new plot developments unless I specifically ask you to.

Preserve my creative decisions and individual writing voice. I want to learn to become a better writer, not have AI write my stories for me.

For now, simply acknowledge these instructions and tell me you’re ready for my passage. Wait until I provide it before beginning.

PRACTICAL EXAMPLES FROM *OASIS*

One passage. Three different kinds of feedback.

The following 13 screenshots show real ChatGPT responses to the three complete prompts in this guide. Each exercise uses the same short passage from my fiction. The screenshots are reproduced as captured, rather than rewritten or recreated.

The original passage

> *The caravan moved slowly towards Midway Oasis. It was dark. the sun had long set, and the moons were out, casting the dunes into silhouette. The wagons varied is size and cargo. Most transporting goods to trade, one carrying two travellers.*

How to read these examples

Exercise 1 demonstrates a light edit and the reasons behind it. Exercise 2 examines grammar and sentence construction in detail. Exercise 3 looks at storytelling craft: what the passage achieves, what could be improved and what the writer can learn.

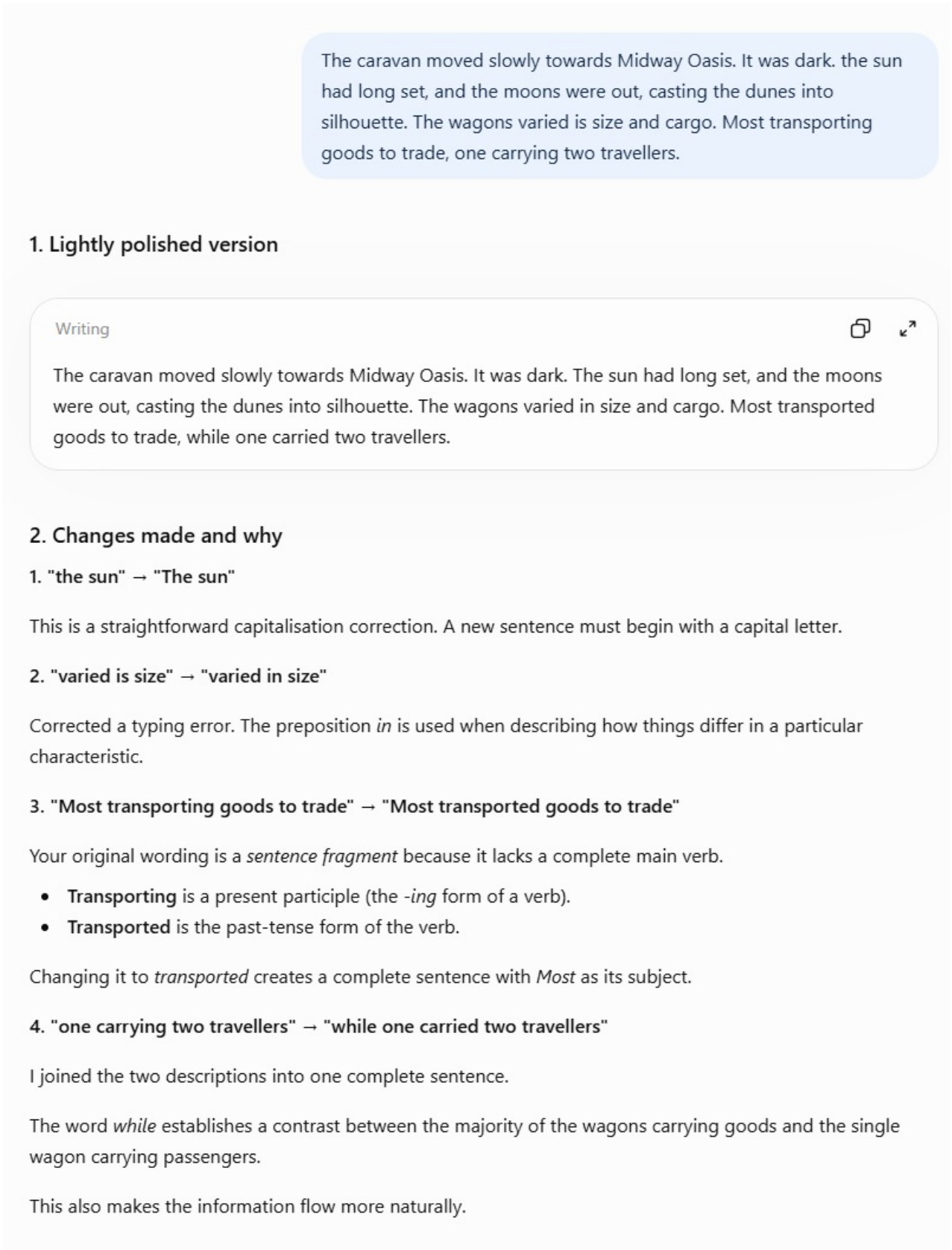
Compare the responses, rather than treating them as verdicts. In one exercise ChatGPT revises the final sentence fragment; in another it explains that fragments can sometimes be effective in fiction. A sentence fragment is a sentence-like group of words without a complete independent clause. A recommendation is not automatically a rule you must follow.

For easy copying, all three prompts remain at the beginning of this PDF. These examples are supplementary reading.

EXERCISE 1 | LIGHT POLISH

See the revised passage and explanations of the individual changes.

Original screenshot 1 of 2



The caravan moved slowly towards Midway Oasis. It was dark. the sun had long set, and the moons were out, casting the dunes into silhouette. The wagons varied is size and cargo. Most transporting goods to trade, one carrying two travellers.

1. Lightly polished version

Writing

The caravan moved slowly towards Midway Oasis. It was dark. The sun had long set, and the moons were out, casting the dunes into silhouette. The wagons varied in size and cargo. Most transported goods to trade, while one carried two travellers.

2. Changes made and why

1. "the sun" → "The sun"

This is a straightforward capitalisation correction. A new sentence must begin with a capital letter.

2. "varied is size" → "varied in size"

Corrected a typing error. The preposition *in* is used when describing how things differ in a particular characteristic.

3. "Most transporting goods to trade" → "Most transported goods to trade"

Your original wording is a *sentence fragment* because it lacks a complete main verb.

- **Transporting** is a present participle (the *-ing* form of a verb).
- **Transported** is the past-tense form of the verb.

Changing it to *transported* creates a complete sentence with *Most* as its subject.

4. "one carrying two travellers" → "while one carried two travellers"

I joined the two descriptions into one complete sentence.

The word *while* establishes a contrast between the majority of the wagons carrying goods and the single wagon carrying passengers.

This also makes the information flow more naturally.

EXERCISE 1 | LIGHT POLISH

Original screenshot 2 of 2

3. Writing techniques to learn

Sentence fragments

A complete sentence normally needs a subject and a verb that expresses a complete thought.

Consider your original:

Most transporting goods to trade.

- **Subject:** Most (meaning most of the wagons).
- **Verb form:** transporting.
- **Problem:** There is no finite verb (a verb that shows tense and can form the main verb of a clause).

Compare:

Most transported goods to trade.

Now the sentence has a subject and a past-tense verb, making it grammatically complete.

However, **sentence fragments aren't always wrong in fiction.** Writers sometimes use them deliberately for rhythm, emphasis or atmosphere.

Sentence rhythm

I deliberately preserved your opening:

The caravan moved slowly towards Midway Oasis. It was dark.

The short second sentence creates a pause and establishes the atmosphere without unnecessary description.

You don't need to combine these sentences simply to make the prose more elaborate.

Participial phrases

You also wrote:

"*...casting the dunes into silhouette.*"

This is a **participial phrase.** It uses the *-ing* form of a verb to add descriptive information to the main clause.

Here, it describes the visual effect of the moons being out.

It's an effective way of adding atmosphere without creating another complete sentence.

4. Overall feedback

This passage already has a clear progression:

1. The caravan approaches its destination.
2. The darkness and moons establish the setting.
3. The wagons and their contents introduce the travelling group.

Your description is economical, and that works in its favour.

One small observation: The phrase "*casting the dunes into silhouette*" is understandable, although "*casting the dunes into shadow*" would be more conventional. I haven't changed it because *silhouette* creates a particular visual image that you may have intended.

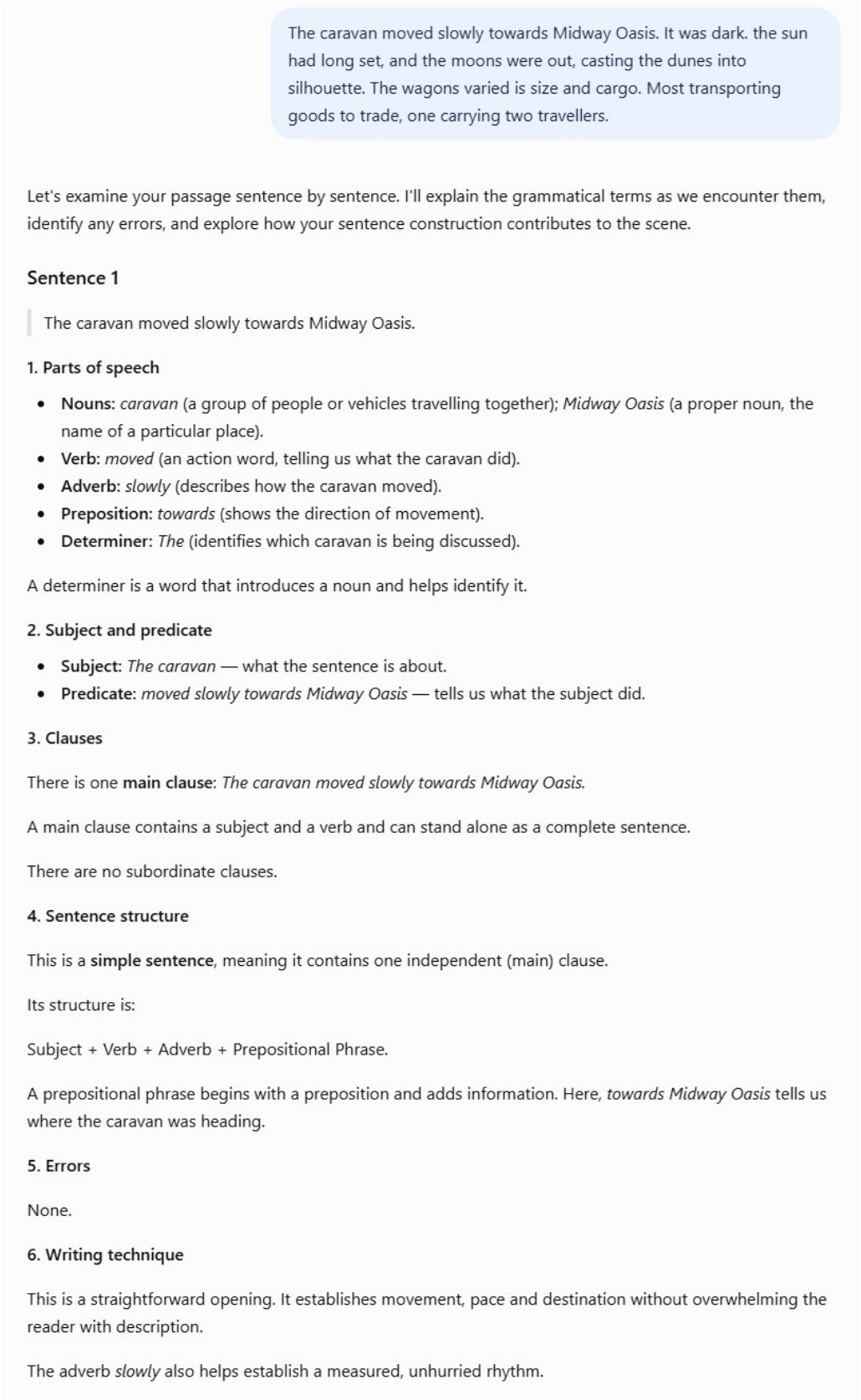
The main corrections were grammatical rather than stylistic. There is no reason to rewrite the passage more extensively.

The lesson here: Good editing isn't about changing as many words as possible. It's about recognising which words need changing and which ones are already doing their job.

EXERCISE 2 | GRAMMAR AND SENTENCES

Follow the sentence-by-sentence breakdown of parts of speech, clauses and structure.

Original screenshot 1 of 6



The caravan moved slowly towards Midway Oasis. It was dark. the sun had long set, and the moons were out, casting the dunes into silhouette. The wagons varied is size and cargo. Most transporting goods to trade, one carrying two travellers.

Let's examine your passage sentence by sentence. I'll explain the grammatical terms as we encounter them, identify any errors, and explore how your sentence construction contributes to the scene.

Sentence 1

> The caravan moved slowly towards Midway Oasis.

1. Parts of speech

- **Nouns:** *caravan* (a group of people or vehicles travelling together); *Midway Oasis* (a proper noun, the name of a particular place).
- **Verb:** *moved* (an action word, telling us what the caravan did).
- **Adverb:** *slowly* (describes how the caravan moved).
- **Preposition:** *towards* (shows the direction of movement).
- **Determiner**: *The* (identifies which caravan is being discussed).

A determiner is a word that introduces a noun and helps identify it.

2. Subject and predicate

- **Subject:** *The caravan* — what the sentence is about.
- **Predicate:** *moved slowly towards Midway Oasis* — tells us what the subject did.

3. Clauses

There is one **main clause**: *The caravan moved slowly towards Midway Oasis.*

A main clause contains a subject and a verb and can stand alone as a complete sentence.

There are no subordinate clauses.

4. Sentence structure

This is a **simple sentence**, meaning it contains one independent (main) clause.

Its structure is:

Subject + Verb + Adverb + Prepositional Phrase.

A prepositional phrase begins with a preposition and adds information. Here, *towards Midway Oasis* tells us where the caravan was heading.

5. Errors

None.

6. Writing technique

This is a straightforward opening. It establishes movement, pace and destination without overwhelming the reader with description.

The adverb *slowly* also helps establish a measured, unhurried rhythm.

EXERCISE 2 | GRAMMAR AND SENTENCES

Original screenshot 2 of 6

Sentence 2

> It was dark.

1. Parts of speech

- **Pronoun:** *It* (a word standing in for something or referring to a situation; here, the surrounding conditions).
- **Verb:** *was* (a linking verb connecting the subject to its description).
- **Adjective:** *dark* (describes the conditions).

2. Subject and predicate

- **Subject:** *It*
- **Predicate:** *was dark*

3. Clauses

One main clause, with no subordinate clauses.

4. Sentence structure

Another simple sentence.

Subject + Linking Verb + Adjective.

The adjective *dark* is called a **subject complement** because it completes the description of the subject.

5. Errors

None.

6. Writing technique

The short sentence creates a pause after the caravan's movement.

This is an effective example of **sentence-length variation**: using sentences of different lengths to control the rhythm and pace of your writing.

EXERCISE 2 | GRAMMAR AND SENTENCES

Original screenshot 3 of 6

Sentence 3

> the sun had long set, and the moons were out, casting the dunes into silhouette.

1. Parts of speech

- **Nouns:** *sun, moons, dunes, silhouette.*
- **Verbs:** *had set* (a past perfect verb phrase), *were* (a linking verb), *casting* (a present participle).
- **Adverb:** *long* (indicates how much earlier the sun had set).
- **Conjunction:** *and* (joins two main clauses).
- **Preposition:** *into* (indicates a change into a particular visual state).
- **Determiners:** *the* (appearing before sun, moons and dunes).

A **past perfect** verb describes something that had already happened before another point in the past.

A **present participle** is the *-ing* form of a verb, which can be used to add information about an action.

2. Subject and predicate

This sentence has two main clauses, each with its own subject and predicate.

First clause:

- Subject: *the sun*
- Predicate: *had long set*

Second clause:

- Subject: *the moons*
- Predicate: *were out*

3. Clauses

- **Main clause 1:** *the sun had long set*
- **Main clause 2:** *the moons were out*
- **Participial clause:** *casting the dunes into silhouette*

The participial clause is a non-finite subordinate clause. This means its verb, *casting*, does not independently indicate tense.

It adds information about the effect of the moons being out.

4. Sentence structure

This is a **compound-complex sentence** under an analysis that counts the participial clause as subordinate.

A compound sentence contains two or more main clauses. A complex sentence contains a main clause and at least one subordinate clause.

Here, you have both.

The conjunction *and* connects the two main clauses, while the participial clause extends the description.

5. Errors

There is one definite punctuation error: *the* should be capitalised because it begins a new sentence.

6. Writing technique

The participial clause *casting the dunes into silhouette* creates a visual image without requiring another complete sentence.

It also allows the description to flow naturally from the presence of the moons to their effect on the landscape.

One stylistic consideration: *casting the dunes into silhouette* is understandable, although slightly unusual phrasing. That is not a grammatical error.

EXERCISE 2 | GRAMMAR AND SENTENCES

Original screenshot 4 of 6

Sentence 4

> The wagons varied is size and cargo.

1. Parts of speech

- **Nouns:** *wagons*, *size*, *cargo*.
- **Verb:** *varied*.
- **Conjunction:** *and*.
- **Determiner:** *The*.

The word *is* appears to be a typing error for the preposition *in*.

2. Subject and predicate

- **Subject:** *The wagons*
- **Predicate:** *varied in size and cargo* (once corrected).

3. Clauses

One main clause, with no subordinate clauses.

4. Sentence structure

A simple sentence.

Subject + Verb + Prepositional Phrase.

The phrase *in size and cargo* identifies the respects in which the wagons differed.

5. Errors

is should be *in*.

Corrected:

> The wagons varied in size and cargo.

6. Writing technique

This sentence moves from the wider landscape to the caravan itself.

That is a useful narrative technique: beginning with the overall scene and gradually narrowing the reader's attention towards particular details.

EXERCISE 2 | GRAMMAR AND SENTENCES

Original screenshot 5 of 6

Sentence 5

> Most transporting goods to trade, one carrying two travellers.

1. Parts of speech

- **Pronouns:** *Most* (referring to most of the wagons), *one* (referring to a single wagon).
- **Verbs:** *transporting*, *carrying* (present participles).
- **Nouns:** *goods*, *travellers*.
- **Verb:** *trade* (in its infinitive form).
- **Numeral/determiner:** *two* (specifies the number of travellers).
- **Infinitive marker:** *to* (introduces the verb *trade*).

An **infinitive** is the base form of a verb, often preceded by *to*, such as *to walk*, *to write* or *to trade*.

2. Subject and predicate

You have two implied descriptions:

- *Most transporting goods to trade*
- *one carrying two travellers*

Although *Most* and *one* act as subjects within these constructions, neither has a finite verb.

A **finite verb** is a verb form that shows tense or is otherwise grammatically anchored to a subject, allowing a clause to function independently.

3. Clauses

These are non-finite clauses rather than complete independent clauses.

The phrase *to trade* is also a non-finite infinitival clause expressing purpose.

4. Sentence structure

As written, this is a **sentence fragment**.

A sentence fragment is a group of words presented as a complete sentence even though it lacks something normally required, such as an independent clause.

Both *transporting* and *carrying* describe ongoing actions, but neither forms a complete finite verb phrase here.

5. Errors

In conventional formal grammar, this is incomplete as a standalone sentence.

However, fiction writers frequently use fragments deliberately for rhythm, emphasis or compressed description.

So the important distinction is:

- **Grammatically:** It is a fragment.
- **Stylistically:** It may be intentional and perfectly usable in fiction.

The comma separating the two descriptions is not inherently incorrect; the issue is that the overall construction lacks a main clause.

6. Writing technique

There is something effective happening here.

You establish a contrast between the majority of wagons carrying trading goods and one carrying two travellers.

That final detail subtly directs the reader's attention towards the travellers, suggesting that they may become important.

This is a useful example of how sentence construction can guide a reader's attention without explicitly telling them what matters.

EXERCISE 2 | GRAMMAR AND SENTENCES

Original screenshot 6 of 6

Overall assessment

Your passage demonstrates several useful fiction-writing techniques.

What is working well: You establish location, movement and atmosphere efficiently. Your sentences vary in length, and the description progresses from the landscape towards the people travelling through it.

What needs attention: There is one capitalisation error, one likely typing error (*is* instead of *in*), and a final sentence fragment that you can either retain deliberately or develop into a complete sentence.

An important lesson: Grammatical correctness and effective fiction writing are not always the same thing. Understanding the rules gives you the freedom to break them deliberately, rather than accidentally.

And that is precisely the skill we're working towards.

EXERCISE 3 | FICTION-WRITING CRAFT

Explore the feedback on atmosphere, worldbuilding, pacing and reader attention.

Original screenshot 1 of 5

Creative Writing Analysis

Your original passage

> The caravan moved slowly towards Midway Oasis. It was dark. the sun had long set, and the moons were out, casting the dunes into silhouette. The wagons varied is size and cargo. Most transporting goods to trade, one carrying two travellers.

1. What is working well?

Establishing the scene

Your opening sentence immediately gives the reader three pieces of information: something is moving, where it is going, and how quickly it is travelling.

"The caravan moved slowly towards Midway Oasis."

This is an example of **scene-setting**: establishing the location, circumstances and physical activity at the beginning of a scene.

Creating atmosphere

"The sun had long set, and the moons were out, casting the dunes into silhouette."

This is your strongest descriptive sentence.

You're using **visual imagery**, which means creating a picture in the reader's imagination through descriptive language.

The multiple moons also introduce an element of **worldbuilding**: revealing details about your fictional world naturally through the narrative.

You don't stop to explain why there are multiple moons. You simply present them as part of the world.

That's an effective technique.

Introducing a point of interest

"Most transporting goods to trade, one carrying two travellers."

By distinguishing one wagon from the others, you're directing the reader's attention towards the two travellers.

This creates a subtle sense of curiosity: Who are these travellers, and why might they matter?

EXERCISE 3 | FICTION-WRITING CRAFT

Original screenshot 2 of 5

2. What could be improved?

Sentence construction

"It was dark. the sun had long set..."

There is a straightforward capitalisation error: "the" should begin with a capital letter.

More importantly, "It was dark" tells the reader something that the following sentence already communicates through description.

This creates a small amount of **redundancy**, meaning information is repeated without necessarily adding anything new.

However, short sentences can be useful for controlling rhythm, so removing one isn't automatically an improvement.

Grammar and sentence fragments

"The wagons varied is size and cargo."

The word "is" should be "in".

"Most transporting goods to trade, one carrying two travellers."

This is a **sentence fragment** because it lacks a finite verb that would make it a complete independent sentence.

A finite verb is a verb form that establishes tense, such as "carried" or "were transporting".

Sentence fragments aren't always mistakes in fiction. Writers deliberately use them for emphasis, rhythm or a particular narrative voice.

Here, though, the fragment reads more like an unfinished sentence than an intentional stylistic choice.

Description and specificity

"The wagons varied in size and cargo."

This communicates information clearly but remains quite general.

You could consider whether the differences between the wagons are important enough to deserve more description.

However, additional detail isn't automatically better. If the wagons are simply background information, your concise approach may be entirely appropriate.

EXERCISE 3 | FICTION-WRITING CRAFT

Original screenshot 3 of 5

3. Writing techniques you're already using

Technique	Example	What it achieves
Scene-setting	"The caravan moved slowly..."	Establishes movement and destination
Visual imagery	"casting the dunes into silhouette"	Creates a mental picture
Worldbuilding	"the moons were out"	Reveals something about your fictional world
Pacing	"moved slowly"	Establishes an unhurried opening
Narrative focus	"one carrying two travellers"	Draws attention to particular characters
Third-person narration	"The caravan moved..."	Describes events from outside the characters

One important distinction: although you're using third-person narration, this short passage doesn't yet establish whether the story will follow one character's perspective or use a broader narrator.

That distinction will become clearer as the scene develops.

EXERCISE 3 | FICTION-WRITING CRAFT

Original screenshot 4 of 5

4. What can you learn from this passage?

There are three particularly useful lessons here.

First: Description can perform several jobs simultaneously.

Your sentence about the moons establishes the time of day, creates atmosphere and introduces an aspect of your fictional world.

This is an example of efficient storytelling.

Second: Sentence length influences how a reader experiences a scene.

Your passage combines short statements with a longer descriptive sentence.

This creates variation in **sentence rhythm**, meaning the pattern and flow of sentences as they're read.

Learning to control that rhythm will help you influence pacing and atmosphere.

Third: Not every detail needs explaining.

You introduce Midway Oasis, multiple moons and two travellers without providing their histories.

This allows the reader to discover your world gradually rather than receiving all the information at once.

That's an important storytelling skill.

EXERCISE 3 | FICTION-WRITING CRAFT

Original screenshot 5 of 5

5. Overall assessment

Your passage establishes a clear scene with economical description. Its strongest feature is the image of the moonlit dunes, which introduces atmosphere and worldbuilding without interrupting the narrative.

The main areas requiring attention are sentence construction, punctuation and deciding where additional descriptive detail would genuinely benefit the reader.

There isn't enough material yet to assess characterisation, dialogue, subtext or sustained point of view, and I wouldn't manufacture criticisms in those areas.

Your key takeaway: You're already combining setting, atmosphere and worldbuilding within a small amount of prose. The next skill to develop is greater control over sentence structure and rhythm, while preserving that economical approach to storytelling.